

RUSSELL RESURGENCE

The Mercedes driver **reignites** his title challenge with a crucial victory in Austria.

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Formula 1 races are often slow burners. A combination of pit strategy, tyre wear and track evolution often results in races building up to a grand climax. The 2026 Austrian Grand Prix was a classic example.

Fans were treated to a humdinger in the foothills of the Styrian mountains as the top three cars were separated by less than two seconds. And for the first time since the season-opening Australian Grand Prix, it was the Mercedes of George Russell that caught the chequered flag, finishing ahead of

Max Verstappen and teammate Kimi Antonelli.

"The tough races definitely test you psychologically, and these last two weekends for me have been vitally important to remind myself I can do it," said Russell, who bagged P2 in Barcelona last time out.

The importance of this win for the 28-year-old Briton cannot be understated. He had conceded a significant lead in the drivers' standings to Antonelli, who reeled off five Grand Prix victories in a row between March and June. His weekend at the Red Bull Ring also began on the back foot. Russell was consistently at least three tenths behind the Italian throughout free practice.

But a controversial final lap in qualifying changed everything. Despite Verstappen ending up in the wall at the final turn, Russell registered his best lap time to catapult to the top of the timing sheets even as Antonelli pulled out of the lap following the crash. The Ferrari duo of Charles Leclerc and Lewis Hamilton thought they had stolen the front row of the grid from their faster rival until Russell sped through the final sector to snatch pole position.

It was a nervous wait to see if the lap time would count and Russell explained later in the media chat that he had taken his foot off the accelerator well in advance after seeing the yellow flags waving. The stewards eventually sided with the Mercedes driver and that proved to be the turning point he needed during the weekend.

A rapid getaway at the start of the race helped him create a sizeable lead ahead of the scarlet cars. But Russell's biggest threat came from the less fancied Red Bull of four-time world champion Verstappen. The 1.6-second margin at the finish could very well have been wiped out had the Milton Keynes outfit played its strategy cards slightly better.

Verstappen had come within a second of the Mercedes during the second stint before the leading car jetted into the pits. Instead of following him in on the next lap, the team opted to go long in the hope of fighting Russell with fresher tyres towards the end. A

